

From a learner to a changemaker : The Journey of Prasenjit Mandal

Prasenjit Mandal, a dedicated youth volunteer from Rajgram Kora Para, has transformed his life—and the lives of many children around him—through education and consistent community engagement.

In the beginning, the journey wasn't easy. Prasenjit had to walk or cycle several kilometers to reach the PAG sessions. At first, he struggled with the long distances and the lack of a dedicated learning space. Children had to sit and study under the open sky, facing sun and rain. But with support from CRY and the community, a permanent space was eventually arranged. These early challenges only made Prasenjit stronger and more determined.

Motivated by CRY's online training sessions and the belief that small efforts can create big change, he began teaching children regularly. He started with a small group of 10–12 children, mostly in the age group of 6 to 14 years, studying up to Class 8. As time passed, and more parents began noticing the positive changes in their children, the number grew. Today, he guides and supports over 100 children—proof of how deeply his efforts are valued by the community.

From teaching only twice a week, Prasenjit gradually made it a regular practice. His confidence grew alongside his commitment. He developed better public speaking and leadership skills, and discovered a passion for helping children grow. He became a mentor to many, particularly those from tribal communities, helping them build dreams and goals they never thought possible.

In the PAG sessions, Prasenjit does more than just help with schoolwork. He encourages creativity through drawing, art, and language games. He also introduces life skills—like how to behave respectfully at school and at home, the importance of good manners, and even basic knowledge of banking and career options. During festivals or local events, he involves children in making decorations or participating in cultural programs, which helps build their confidence.

His efforts have shown clear results. Children who earlier couldn't write their names or recognize alphabets now write and read with ease. Many now speak simple English and show confidence in class. One child in Class 6, who once scored just 30–40%, now scores 70–80%. Local teachers have noticed this shift and often appreciate the improvement in students' academic performance and discipline.

Prasenjit also engages with parents to help them understand the value of regular study, attendance, and support at home. He believes change can happen faster when families are involved.

When asked for suggestions, Prasenjit says that PAG sessions should be held at least five days a week instead of two, since children are showing real interest and learn more with regular sessions. He also feels that youth like him should be encouraged and trained more, as they understand the children in their own communities the best.

Would he recommend volunteering in PAGs to others? Without hesitation. According to him, this experience doesn't just build your confidence and discipline, it gives you a sense of purpose. It teaches you patience, teamwork, and how to be part of something bigger than yourself.

“Earlier, I was shy and unsure. But today, I can stand in front of a group and teach with confidence. Seeing the children smile and grow is the biggest reward of all,” says Prasenjit with pride.

From a quiet village youth to a trusted community educator, Prasenjit's journey is a powerful example of how consistent effort, proper guidance, and the right support system can create lasting change—for one, and for many.

Bridging Gaps , Building Futures : Abhi Konai's Journey of Empowerment in

Birbhum

At just 25, Abhi Konai has already spent three transformative years volunteering with CRY (Child Rights and You), dedicating himself to empowering children from tribal communities in Birbhum, West Bengal. Abhi currently serves as a Project Coordinator and has become a pillar of hope for children who once had limited access to education and guidance.

When Abhi first joined the CRY initiative, he was introduced by Chandra Nath Sir, who explained their goal: to provide free weekend education to children from tribal areas, where formal schooling is scarce. With no nearby schools and many families unfamiliar with the value of regular education, Abhi began his journey by visiting children's homes to build trust with their families. "I would tell them stories and play games. Slowly, they felt more comfortable and started attending sessions," Abhi recalls. What started as casual storytelling turned into structured teaching, and a powerful bond formed between the volunteer and the children.

The challenges were evident. Most children struggled with a language barrier, as Bengali was not their mother tongue. This, combined with poor access to formal education and unsafe travel conditions to distant schools, led to high dropout rates. Many children would spend their days collecting mid-day meals or grazing cattle, with little awareness of academic opportunities. But the learning center changed that.

"The change has been significant," Abhi shares. "Children who couldn't read are now identifying letters, reading sentences, and even expressing themselves better in Bengali and English." Through interactive methods involving stories, games, and basic life skills sessions, Abhi and his team have helped students build confidence, understand their lessons better, and even develop improved personal hygiene, manners, and discipline.

Abhi primarily conducts sessions with students from classes 7 and 8, covering subjects like Geography and History. However, the learning extends beyond textbooks. He introduces students to life skills through drawing, role-play, and behavioral etiquette. "We prepare them for school and also for life—how to behave, how to dream, and how to pursue those dreams," he says proudly.

One particularly inspiring success story that Abhi holds dear is that of a young boy from Rajgram Kora Para. "He used to graze cattle and had no interest in school. He barely spoke, let alone read or wrote. But once he started attending our sessions regularly, everything changed." With sustained mentorship, the boy developed an interest in studies, especially in Bengali. Today, he attends school regularly, performs well in exams, and remains a consistent learner at the weekend center.

Despite the positive impact, Abhi acknowledges logistical challenges, especially during the monsoon. Sessions are currently held in an area with a tin roof that leaks during rain, often forcing cancellations. "A proper, waterproof space would make a big difference," he suggests. It's a practical observation, reflecting his growing awareness of educational infrastructure needs.

Abhi feels fully supported by CRY, crediting the organization for equipping him with training and tools that make his sessions more effective. “Their sessions have strengthened my understanding of child development and teaching techniques,” he says. The support has also helped Abhi grow personally. Through this experience, he has improved his planning, communication, and organizational skills. He has also learned how to handle documentation and submit bills—important administrative skills that complement his teaching.

When asked if he would recommend volunteering in PAGs, Abhi’s response is unwavering. “Absolutely. The more volunteers we have, the more children we can reach. It’s not just about teaching; it’s about standing beside them, guiding them both academically and emotionally.”

Abhi Konai’s journey is a testament to how one individual, with commitment and compassion, can transform lives and bridge the gap between exclusion and opportunity. His story not only highlights the impact of grassroots education but also reinforces the importance of community-driven change.